

Muhammad Yunus

Muhammad Yunus^[a] (born 28 June 1940) is a Bangladeshi economist, entrepreneur, politician, and civil society leader, who has been serving as Chief Adviser of the Interim Government of Bangladesh since 8 August 2024.^[1] Yunus was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize in 2006 for founding the Grameen Bank and pioneering the concepts of microcredit and microfinance.^[2] Yunus has received several other national and international honors, including the United States Presidential Medal of Freedom in 2009 and the Congressional Gold Medal in 2010.^[3] Yunus is one of only seven people in the world to have received all of these awards.

In 2012, Yunus became Chancellor of Glasgow Caledonian University in Scotland, a position he held until 2018.^{[4][5]} Previously, he was a professor of economics at Chittagong University in Bangladesh.^[6] He published several books related to his finance work. He is a founding board member of Grameen America and Grameen Foundation, which support microcredit.^[7] Yunus also served on the board of directors of the United Nations Foundation, a public charity to support UN causes, from 1998 to 2021.^[8] In 2022, he partnered with Global Esports Federation as part of the *Esports for Development (E4D)* movement to support the development of Esports.^{[9][10]}

Following the overthrow of Sheikh Hasina, President Mohammed Shahabuddin gave Yunus a mandate to form an interim government, acceding to calls from student leaders for his appointment.^[11] His government has appointed a Constitutional Reform Commission to draft a revision to the Constitution of Bangladesh and has pledged the convocation of a constituent assembly.^[12] His acquittal on appeal the following day of charges of labour code violations, which were viewed as politically motivated, facilitated his return to the country and appointment.^[13] His name was listed in *The 500 Most Influential Muslims* in 2024.^[14]

Early years

The third of nine children,^[15] Muhammad Yunus was born on 28 June 1940 to a Bengali family of Muslim Saudagars in the village of Bathua, by the Kaptai road at Hathazari in the

Chittagong District of Bengal Presidency (now in Bangladesh).^{[16][17]} His father was Haji Muhammad Dula Mia Soudagar, a jeweller, and his mother was Sufia Khatun. His early childhood was spent in the village. In 1944, his family moved to the city of Chittagong, and he moved from his village school to Lamabazar Primary School.^{[16][18]} By 1949, his mother was afflicted with psychological illness.^[17] Later, he passed the matriculation examination from Chittagong Collegiate School ranking 16th out of 39,000 students in East Pakistan.^[18] During his school years, he was an active Boy Scout, and travelled to West Pakistan and India in 1952, and to Canada in 1955 to attend Jamborees.^[18] Later, while Yunus was studying at Chittagong College, he became active in cultural activities and won awards for drama.^[18] In 1957, he enrolled in the Department of Economics at Dhaka University and completed his BA in 1960 and MA in 1961.^{[19][20]}

After graduation

After his graduation, Yunus joined the Bureau of Economics as a research assistant to the economics researches of Nurul Islam and Rehman Sobhan.^[18] Later, he was appointed lecturer in economics in Chittagong College in 1961.^[18] During that time, he also set up a profitable packaging factory on the side.^[17] In 1965, he received a Fulbright scholarship to study in the United States. He obtained his PhD in economics from the Vanderbilt University Graduate Program in Economic Development (GPED) in 1971.^{[21][22]} From 1969 to 1972, Yunus was the assistant professor of economics at Middle Tennessee State University in Murfreesboro.^{[19][20]}

During the Bangladesh Liberation War in 1971, Yunus founded a citizen's committee and ran the Bangladesh Information Center, with other Bangladeshis in the United States, to raise support for liberation.^[18] He also published the *Bangladesh Newsletter* from his home in Nashville. After the War, he returned to Bangladesh and was appointed to the government's Planning Commission headed by Nurul Islam. However, he found the job boring and resigned to join Chittagong University as head of the Economics department.^[23] After observing the famine of 1974, he became involved in poverty reduction and established a rural economic programme as a research project. In 1975, he developed a *Nabajug Tebhaga Khamar* (lit. 'New Era Three-share Farm') which the government adopted as the Packaged Input Programme.^[18] To make the project more effective, Yunus and his associates proposed the *Gram Sarkar* (lit. 'Village government') programme.^[24] Introduced by President Ziaur Rahman in the late 1970s, the government formed 40,392 village governments as a fourth layer of government in 2003. On 2 August 2005, in response to a

petition by Bangladesh Legal Aid and Services Trust (BLAST), the High Court declared village governments illegal and unconstitutional.^[25]

His concept of microcredit for supporting innovators in multiple developing countries also inspired programmes such as the Info lady Social Entrepreneurship Programme.^{[26][27][28]}